MONTHLY UPDATE

Eswatini: monthly update, September – October 2026

Edition of 2026-10-16-3 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

Developments reported in sources published between the beginning of last month and today, grouped by story, oldest first.

STATUS · PROGRESS · INSTITUTION HOSTING

GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA

Governance

Legislation and regulation · Data protection · Regional collaboration

Legislation and regulation

IMMIGRATION BILL TRAVELLER VETTING SYSTEM

- **New proposed law to screen foreigners entering country** — Times of Eswatini, 10 September 2026

  Eswatini's Immigration Bill would set up an information system to vet foreign nationals before entry and block those who fail requirements or are judged a risk. It was discussed at a consultation between Parliament and stakeholders in Ezulwini. The workshop heard that implementation would cost about E6 million.

Data protection

DATA PROTECTION AUTHORITY COMMUNITY OUTREACH CAMPAIGN

- **EDPA takes data protection services closer to Emaswati** — Eswatini Positive News, 17 September 2026

  Eswatini's Data Protection Authority is setting up information desks in major towns to give the public and businesses guidance on data-protection rights, responsibilities and registration. It began the outreach after finding that about eight in ten visitors to its trade fair stand had limited knowledge of the Data Protection Act.

Regional collaboration

COOPERATION TALKS WITH THE DIGITAL COOPERATION ORGANIZATION

- **Eswatini and DCO explore cooperation to accelerate digital transformation** — TechReview Africa, 3 September 2026

  The Digital Cooperation Organization's secretary-general, Deemah AlYahya, met Eswatini's ICT minister Savannah Maziya to discuss cooperation on digital transformation through knowledge exchange and capacity building. The report cites about 1.76 million mobile connections for a population of 1.3 million and 4G coverage of nearly 95 per cent. No agreement was announced.

COMMUNICATIONS REGULATORS' MEMORANDUM WITH LESOTHO

- **Eswatini, Lesotho Join Forces to Tackle Cyber Threats** — Eswatini Positive News, 7 October 2026 LESOTHO

> The Eswatini Communications Commission and the Lesotho Communications Authority signed a memorandum of understanding on 3 October 2026 covering information exchange, joint research, staff development and cybersecurity cooperation, including coordinated incident response, awareness campaigns, training and audits. No budget or timetable is given.

Finance

New investments

New investments

DIGITAL ESWATINI PROJECT

- **EPTC seeks E455m loan for digital transformation** — Times of Eswatini, 10 September 2026

  Eswatini's posts and telecommunications corporation is seeking a US$26 million World Bank loan to finance the Digital Eswatini Project, under a bill tabled in Parliament. The bill would authorise the finance minister to issue a government guarantee of up to that amount for the loan.

- **E455m EPTC loan puts taxpayers on the line** — Independent News Eswatini, 21 September 2026

  Eswatini's House of Assembly took the second reading of three bills on 21 September 2026 financing the US$65 million World Bank Digital Eswatini Project. MPs focused on the US$26 million (about E455 million) loan to the state telecoms company EPTC, which the government would guarantee. The finance minister said that loan pays for EPTC's financial stabilisation and a change in its pension scheme, repayable from 2034 to 2051; the other two facilities fund broadband to Tinkhundla centres, schools and clinics, online government services, digital ID, payments and skills training. The bills now go to committee.

- **MPs BACK E1.14BN DIGITAL LOANS - Eswatini Positive News** — Eswatini Positive News, 21 September 2026

  Eswatini MPs spoke in support of the three World Bank facilities, together worth US$65 million (about E1.14 billion), that fund the Digital Eswatini Project, at the bills' second reading. The debate is summarised under the Eswatini Independent's report.

- **IDEA Half-Year Implementation Progress Report: January-June 2026 and Outlook for July-December 2026** — COMESA Secretariat (IDEA project), 1 October 2026 ANGOLA DRC MALAWI ZAMBIA EAST AFRICA SOUTHERN AFRICA

  COMESA's half-year progress report on the World Bank-financed Inclusive Digitalisation in Eastern and Southern Africa programme, a US$2.48 billion envelope, covers January to June 2026 in Angola, the DRC, Malawi, Zambia and Eswatini. The COMESA secretariat had spent 9% of its US$3.71 million 2026 budget by June, and moved its AI and regional digital inclusion consultancies from procurement to implementation.

- **Who was held accountable for EPTC pension crisis?- Sen. Tony** — The Independent News Eswatini, 6 October 2026

  Eswatini senators asked on 5 October whether anyone had been held to account for the pension crisis at the state posts and telecommunications corporation, after Parliament approved the government guarantee for its US$26 million World Bank loan under the Digital Eswatini Project. The ICT minister said E26 million of the loan goes to the post office pension fund, affecting about 500 employees, and that the bank will manage and audit the loan.

ICT Infrastructure

Data Storage · Cybersecurity

Data Storage

NATIONAL DATA CENTRE DISASTER RECOVERY SITE

- **Govt seeks to cancel E182m data recovery site loan** — Times of Eswatini, 22 September 2026

  Eswatini's Finance Minister Neal Rijkenberg told Parliament that the Treasury has asked Exim Bank of India to cancel an undrawn US$10.4 million loan, about E182 million, for a government data recovery site in the Lubombo Region. The project stalled and no work has taken place, while commitment fees continue to accrue. The bank has not yet confirmed the cancellation.

- **Govt systems crippled by digital outages** — Independent News Eswatini, 23 September 2026

  Eswatini's ICT ministry acknowledged outages across government online services, including elderly grants, e-Visa, road permits, scholarships, deeds registration and the IFMIS, without giving a cause. It did not confirm a reported breach at the Royal Science and Technology Park, home of the National Data Centre, or a reported EUR 1 million ransom demand.

- **E182m data centre loan not cancelled - Neal** — Times of Eswatini, 5 October 2026

  Eswatini's finance ministry says the E182 million India Exim Bank loan for a disaster recovery site at Siteki has not been cancelled. What the minister meant in Parliament was the commitment fee on the undrawn balance, which the lender has agreed to stop; 1% of the loan has been drawn.

NATIONAL DATA CENTRE

- **Govt systems crippled by digital outages** — Independent News Eswatini, 23 September 2026

  Summarised under Data Storage.

- **National Data Centre hit by 'incident'** — Times of Eswatini, 24 September 2026

  Eswatini's Royal Science and Technology Park confirmed that an incident at the National Data Centre disrupted at least 12 government digital services, including e-Visa, company registration, the government website and the financial management system. It did not confirm social-media claims of a hack or ransom demand, and said outside experts were helping restore services.

- **INTERPOL roped in on RSTP incident** — Times of Eswatini, 28 September 2026

  Eswatini's police have engaged INTERPOL over the incident at the National Data Centre and will investigate once a consultant hired by the science park and the ICT ministry reports. Unnamed sources suspect a third-party client gave attackers a way in; preliminary findings point to corrupted files and no data stolen.

Cybersecurity

CYBERCRIME UNIT IN THE DIRECTORATE OF PUBLIC PROSECUTIONS

- **Minister Savannah launches cybersecurity awareness month** — Independent News Eswatini, 1 October 2026

  Eswatini's ICT minister launched National Cybersecurity Awareness Month and said a review of the National Cybersecurity Strategy has begun. The Director of Public Prosecutions said her office has set up a Cybercrime Unit and trained prosecutors on the 2022 cybercrime Act.

NATIONAL CYBERSECURITY AWARENESS PROGRAMME

- **Minister Savannah launches cybersecurity awareness month** — Independent News Eswatini, 1 October 2026

  Summarised under Cybersecurity.

NATIONAL CYBERSECURITY STRATEGY REVIEW

- **Minister Savannah launches cybersecurity awareness month** — Independent News Eswatini, 1 October 2026

  Summarised under Cybersecurity.

NATIONAL CYBER DRILL

- **ESCCOM HOSTS INAUGURAL NATIONAL CYBER DRILL TO STRENGTHEN ESWATINI'S CYBER RESILIENCE** — The Bridge, 8 October 2026

  Eswatini held its first national cyber drill on 5 October: a multi-sector ransomware simulation for energy, telecoms, government, aviation, health and finance, facilitated by Lesotho's regulator. The communications commission showed a prototype incident-sharing platform.

DPI

Digital Identity and CRVS · Digital Payments and Fintech · Registries · Sectoral management information systems · Other GovTech and e-Gov

Digital Identity and CRVS

IDENTITY CARD AND PASSPORT PROCESSING AT HOME AFFAIRS

- **Network blackout strikes Home Affairs, EPTC** — Times of Eswatini, 16 September 2026

  A network outage on 16 September 2026 halted all identity card and passport processing at Eswatini's Home Affairs headquarters in Mbabane and at postal counters, with no restoration time given. Pupils needing original ID cards to sit examinations that week were among those turned away.

NATIONAL IDENTITY CARD

- **'Cat' Matlala wife arrest reignites Eswatini ID saga** — Independent News Eswatini, 23 September 2026

  Eswatini's Civil Service Commission found in September 2026 that suspended Home Affairs assistant registrar Nonhlanhla Malambe unlawfully issued a birth certificate and national ID card to a foreign national registered as 'Vusimuzi Dlamini', using an innocent citizen's details. The documents were issued in February 2024 and are allegedly used by South African businessman Vusimuzi 'Cat' Matlala; criminal proceedings continue.

Digital Payments and Fintech

UNAYO MOBILE BANKING PLATFORM

- **Standard Bank eyes integrated banking as Unayo phased out** — Eswatini Observer, 9 September 2026

  Standard Bank Eswatini will close its Unayo wallet platform on 31 December 2026, the Eswatini Observer reported on 9 September 2026. Unayo has more than 200,000 registered retail customers and about 5,000 business clients, of whom about 30% transact regularly; the bank says the Eswatini Payment Switch now provides the real-time transfers between banks and wallets that Unayo was built to offer.

- **STANDARD BANK REVIVES INSTANT MONEY AS UNAYO EXITS** — Eswatini Positive News, 4 October 2026

  Standard Bank Eswatini has told customers by SMS that its Instant Money service will return as it prepares to close the Unayo digital platform on 31 December 2026. No relaunch date, fees or limits had been announced as of 4 October. Unayo users were advised to withdraw stored funds before the closure.

ESWATINI PAYMENT SWITCH

- **Eswatini payment system enters new era** — Eswatini Observer, 21 September 2026

The Central Bank of Eswatini says the fast-payments service of the Eswatini Payment Switch now links banks and mobile-money providers in real time at any hour, with QR-code payments to merchants being built next. Speaking at Tourism Nkwe 2026 in Mbabane, a deputy director said open banking and a domestic card switch will follow. Links to other countries come at a later stage.

- **DELTAPAY BRINGS INSTANT PAYMENTS CLOSER TO HOME** — Eswatini Positive News, 12 October 2026

  DeltaPay has gone live on the Eswatini Payment Switch, the Central Bank of Eswatini's national switch, letting its wallet users send money within seconds at any time, including weekends, to customers of participating banks and wallets. No go-live date or fees are given.

PROVIDENT FUND DIGITISATION

- **ENPF cuts claims processing from days to three hours** — Times of Eswatini, 7 October 2026

  The Eswatini National Provident Fund launched Express Claims on 6 October 2026, promising payment within three hours for claims of up to E5,000 from members who have completed identity checks, as a pilot. It also launched a debit-card payment gateway for contributions on its portal. Government reporting had put average claim processing at about 1.6 days.

POST OFFICES AS GOVERNMENT PAYMENT POINTS

- **GOVT TO USE POST OFFICES AS COMMUNITY DIGITAL CENTRES – PS PRINCE MASHISHIMBA** — Eswatini Positive News, 9 October 2026

  Eswatini's ICT principal secretary, Prince Mashishimba Andreas Dlamini, said on 9 October 2026, World Post Day, that the government plans to use post offices as community digital centres for public services. Eswatini Post would be brought into e-government work, supporting citizen authentication, document verification and digital payments in rural and underserved areas. No timetable or cost is given.

Registries

NATIONAL POSTCODE AND ADDRESSING PROJECT

- **Matsapha first to roll out addressing system in eight weeks** — Eswatini Positive News, 11 September 2026

  Matsapha became the first municipality in Eswatini to roll out the National Postcode and Addressing Project, with street signs due within eight weeks of 11 September 2026. The scheme, run by the regulator ESCCOM, gives every property a unique address linked to Google Maps. Phase one covers only properties inside the municipal boundary.

VOTER REGISTER

- **Biometric technology set to strengthen voter registration** — Eswatini Positive News, 11 September 2026

  Eswatini's Elections and Boundaries Commission is rolling out continuous voter registration with computers and biometric capture ahead of the 2028 national elections, its deputy chairperson Sipho Tembe said. The system targets people newly turned 18 and those who have changed constituency, and is meant to prevent duplicate registration. No cost or supplier is given.

VOTER REGISTRATION

- **IMBALI REGISTER TO VOTE AHEAD OF ELECTIONS AT MBANGWENI** — Eswatini Positive News, 12 September 2026

> Eswatini's Elections and Boundaries Commission registered young women to vote at the Umhlanga reed dance at Mbangweni Royal Residence, reported on 12 September 2026. Registration requires a personal identification card and uses biometric capture, and the commission paired it with civic education ahead of the coming elections.

> SOCIAL REGISTRY (IMBELEKO)

- **LUBOMBO MPs JOIN DPM TO MAKE EVERY VULNERABLE HOUSEHOLD COUNT - Eswatini Positive News** — Eswatini Positive News, 16 September 2026

  Eswatini's deputy prime minister, Thulisile Dladla, asked Lubombo MPs on 16 September 2026 to build community trust in Imbeleko, the national social registry, before household data collection runs from 12 October to 27 November 2026. 216 data collectors and 22 supervisors have been recruited from the region. The exercise follows enumeration in Shiselweni in 2025.

Sectoral management information systems

> INTEGRATED FINANCIAL MANAGEMENT INFORMATION SYSTEM

- **Govt systems crippled by digital outages** — Independent News Eswatini, 23 September 2026

  Summarised under Data Storage.

- **National Data Centre hit by 'incident'** — Times of Eswatini, 24 September 2026

  Summarised under Data Storage.

- **System glitch stalls civil servants' loans** — Eswatini Observer, 5 October 2026

  An outage of Eswatini government digital services has stopped new loans to civil servants because lenders cannot reach the Integrated Financial Management Information System to check applicants against the 33% salary-deduction limit, reported on 5 October 2026. Instalments on existing loans are still being received. Other platforms affected include e-Visa, the deeds registry and the government website.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

> AUDITOR-GENERAL STRATEGIC PLAN 2026-2030

- **Auditors Embrace AI to Protect Public Funds** — Eswatini Positive News, 7 September 2026

  Eswatini's audit office hosted a week-long peer programme at which supreme audit institutions across the region weighed the use of artificial intelligence in government audit. No tool, pilot, audit methodology or procurement is named.

> E-VISA PLATFORM

- **PM CALLS FOR DISRUPTION TO FIX TOURISM BOTTLENECKS - Eswatini Positive News** — Eswatini Positive News, 17 September 2026

  Eswatini's prime minister, Russell Mmiso Dlamini, told a tourism conference in Mbabane on 17 September 2026 that the e-Visa platform suffers delays and payment failures, worst at peak periods, with no manual fallback. He said the Eswatini Payment Switch already handles fast payments and will add open banking and card switching.

- **Govt systems crippled by digital outages** — Independent News Eswatini, 23 September 2026

  Summarised under Data Storage.

- **National Data Centre hit by 'incident'** — Times of Eswatini, 24 September 2026

  Summarised under Data Storage.

COMPANY REGISTRATION THROUGH THE GOVERNMENT PORTAL

- **National Data Centre hit by 'incident'** — Times of Eswatini, 24 September 2026

  Summarised under Data Storage.

GOVERNMENT IN YOUR HAND CITIZEN APPLICATION

- **National Data Centre hit by 'incident'** — Times of Eswatini, 24 September 2026

  Summarised under Data Storage.

Technology

AI · ICT Industry · Innovation ecosystem

AI

FISCALISATION AND ELECTRONIC INVOICING SYSTEM

- **BE backs ERS e-invoicing but demands practical rollout** — Independent News Eswatini, 7 September 2026

  Eswatini's national business body backed the revenue service's move to electronic invoicing while asking that it be made affordable and workable across existing technologies before national rollout.

- **Retail, wholesale sector steps up for e-invoicing pilot** — Times of Eswatini, 9 September 2026

  Business Eswatini brought its retail and wholesale members together with the Eswatini Revenue Service to explain the revenue service's Electronic Invoicing Solution and prepare for its introduction. A number of businesses volunteered for the pilot phase, in which invoices are to be generated, sent and validated electronically in real time or near real time.

- **Three tech firms connect to ERS e-invoicing system** — Independent News Eswatini, 24 September 2026

  The Eswatini Revenue Service said at the opening of the 2026 filing season, reported on 24 September, that three technology providers, one a young local entrepreneur, are being integrated into its TaxCore e-invoicing system. Businesses' accounting and point-of-sale systems will have to connect to TaxCore to strengthen VAT collection. No start date is given.

NATIONAL AI STRATEGY

- **Eswatini seeks responsible AI use through national strategy** — Eswatini Positive News, 16 September 2026

  Eswatini has hired a consultant to draft a national AI strategy, the ICT minister's representative said at a COMESA regional validation meeting in Ezulwini on 16 September 2026.

ICT Industry

BUY ESWATINI MARKET-ACCESS PLATFORM

- **Taiwan Opens Global Markets for Eswatini Through Buy Eswatini** — Eswatini Positive News, 5 September 2026

  The Taiwan-funded Buy Eswatini digital commerce platform was handed to the Eswatini Investment Promotion Authority at the 58th Eswatini International Trade Fair on 3 September 2026. Eswatini's commerce minister asked Taiwan to fund a third phase covering platform infrastructure, data protection, digital payments, logistics and training for small businesses. No value is given for Taiwan's support or the request.

Innovation ecosystem

SYMPOSIUM ON DIGITAL TOOLS FOR SMALL AND MEDIUM ENTERPRISES

- **Work Smarter: Embrace Technology, Cut Costs, Grow** — United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) Eswatini, 3 September 2026

  About 150 delegates attended a symposium in Manzini, Eswatini, on 2 September 2026 on how small businesses can use technology to cut costs, held under CREATE, a four-year EU-funded government programme. The programme is run by the Ministry of Natural Resources and Energy with the UN Development Programme and Catalyze Eswatini.

FINTECH FORUM ESWATINI

- **FINTECH WORKING GROUP BECOMES FINTECH FORUM ESWATINI** — Eswatini Positive News, 23 September 2026

  The Central Bank of Eswatini's FinTech Working Group became the FinTech Forum Eswatini on 23 September 2026, Governor Phil Mnisi announced at Indaba X Eswatini, opening it to government, academia, industry, innovators and students. A memorandum of understanding to formalise the forum is the next step.

Capacity

Training and skills

Training and skills

DIGITAL SKILLS WORKSHOP SERIES AT THE NATIONAL TRADE FAIR

- **DIGITAL SKILLS OPEN NEW OPPORTUNITIES FOR ESWATINI'S FUTURE - Eswatini Positive News** — Eswatini Positive News - News Website, 2 September 2026

  Eswatini's Ministry of Information, Communications and Technology ran a digital skills workshop series at the 58th Eswatini International Trade Fair in Manzini, held from 28 August to 6 September 2026. Speakers from the University of Eswatini, the Royal Science and Technology Park and the private sector covered digital careers, coding and digital marketing.

SCHOOL ICT EQUIPMENT DONATION

- **Technology devices take schools into digital era – Handsome** — Independent News Eswatini, 15 September 2026

  Eswatini's education minister, Owen Nxumalo, said on 15 September 2026 that Taiwan has donated more than 1,140 computers and 60 printers to 49 schools, and that the cabinet has bought 40 interactive screens, installed in five schools per region, with 106 more schools to follow. He said the ministry has secured a US$4.75m Global Partnership for Education grant for technology in education, without giving its timing.

DIGITAL ESWATINI CHANGE AGENTS

- **E1.06BN DIGITAL ESWATINI PUTS PEOPLE BEFORE TECHNOLOGY** — Eswatini Positive News, 24 September 2026

  About 40 change agents from five ministries and parastatals held a change-readiness workshop in Mbabane on 24 September, assessing their own directorates ahead of implementation of the World Bank-financed Digital Eswatini Project (US$65 million, about E1.06 billion). They are to help public servants adjust to the new digital systems.

Inclusion

Digital divides

Digital divides

SMART AFRICA GENDER IMPACT ASSESSMENT TOOLS FOR DIGITAL POLICY

- **SMART AFRICA TO TEST GENDER IMPACT TOOLS IN ESWATINI** — Eswatini Positive News, 5 October 2026

  Eswatini's ICT ministry is validating three gender impact assessment tools ahead of a Smart Africa workshop in Mbabane from 6 to 8 October 2026, where participants will adapt and pilot them for local digital development programmes. The article does not describe what the tools measure.

- **Gender checks proposed for digital policies** — Times of Eswatini, 7 October 2026 GAMBIA

  Eswatini's ICT minister, opening the gender impact assessment workshop in Mbabane, said the government wants such assessments built into digital policies and programmes before they are implemented.

- **Gender impact tool targets the digital divide facing women** — FinGuard Magazine, 7 October 2026 GAMBIA

  A magazine account of the same Eswatini pilot of Smart Africa's gender impact assessment framework, which is meant to test whether digital programmes narrow the divide facing women. It names the tools differently from the ministry's account.

- **Minister Savannah vows to continue advocating for women In tech** — Independent News Eswatini, 7 October 2026 GAMBIA

  Eswatini's ICT ministry and Smart Africa opened a workshop on 7 October to develop and pilot gender impact assessment tools for digital policy, with Eswatini and The Gambia as pilot countries. Three instruments are to be tested on selected digital policies before validation.

Data

National statistics · Open data

National statistics

FINSCOPE CONSUMER SURVEY

- **Eswatini targets 100% financial inclusion through FinScope survey** — Eswatini Positive News, 10 September 2026

  Eswatini's Central Statistical Office has begun fieldwork for the FinScope 2026 Consumer Survey, covering 3,200 households in all four regions until the end of October 2026. It is the first such survey since 2018, when financial inclusion stood at 87%, and will look at use of banking, mobile money and digital financial services as well as access.

Open data

INVESTMENT ATTRACTIVENESS AND MARKET INTELLIGENCE DASHBOARDS

- **NEW TRADE DASHBOARDS OPEN GLOBAL MARKETS FOR ESWATINI - Eswatini Positive News** — Eswatini Positive News, 18 September 2026

  Eswatini launched two public dashboards, one on investment attractiveness and one on export-market intelligence, built by the trade ministry and the investment promotion authority with the International Trade Centre under EU support. No data licence or update schedule is stated.

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